Colour for your website and business

Yes – but more as a bright accent than as the main voice.

In business yellow is the colour that lifts its head and says “Hey, here I am!” It is **the most visible of colours**, and so it is good to know **when it shouts usefully and when it is merely loud**. This part is not a guide to what you must do, just an aid so you know what yellow promises before you let it into a logo, a website or an advert.

By itself, though, it **does not attract customers** like a magnet. It can help **catch** attention and create **a light, welcoming impression**, but what still decides is mainly what you sell, to whom and how well it all works together.

What we are telling the customer

Yellow can say, for example

“Hey, here I am.” “Something is happening here.” “Come and look.” “Watch out, this is important.”

- **Optimism and lightness.** Yellow is most often linked with **joy**, humour and spontaneity. It suits where you want to improve the mood.
- **Attention.** It is the lightest, and so the eye catches it first. That is why it is used on signs, warnings and notices.
- **Friendliness and youth.** It invites **playfulness** and ideas.
- Caution and care. In the world of traffic yellow means “watch out”. It can thus evoke caution.
- **Legibility.** Yellow text on white is hard to read. What works best is a yellow area with dark (black) lettering.

Depending on the shade, though, it can also feel different. A rich lemon is **more active** and **louder**, butter and sand feel **warm and soft**, gold **festive**, ochre and mustard **earthy and crafted**.

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Simple tips

Yellow as a background, dark lettering

Black or dark lettering on a yellow area reads well, white does not. The most visible pair is yellow with black, and grey, blue and violet (its opposite) also suit it.

Shade by role

Rich yellow for attention and action, butter and sand for warmth, gold for festivity, ochre and mustard for earthiness and craft.

Cultural context

In China and Southeast Asia yellow is the colour of dignity and royal power, in Europe it can also carry old meanings of betrayal and shame. Before you set out into the world, find out what yellow means with you and with them.

Colour blindness

About 1 in 12 men has trouble telling red and green apart. Do not use these two colours as the only difference between two things.

Not the whole website

Large bright areas tire and put customers off.

Yellow as an accent

A button or highlight on a calm background. It is visible and does not shout.

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Professions where it is a Yes

It suits **children, education and play**, creative and entertainment brands, food and breakfast, cafés, travel and sunny services, transport and logistics (taxis, post), **safety and signage**, startups and brands that want to catch attention. Also the personal brand of a woman who wants to be seen, cheerful and imaginative.

Café, bakery, small bistro

Yellow can tell a story of warmth, freshness and a pleasant meeting. **Try an ochre sign, a butter-coloured packaging or a yellow detail on the menu.** For a quiet café a softer shade may feel nicer than a sharp combination of yellow and black. The guest has come for a coffee, not to check the state of the road.

Children's and playful projects

For play, ideas or informal education yellow can be a lovely part of a brand. **But give it space next to a calmer base.** When every picture starts shouting in colour, there is no room left for what you really want to say.

Culture, design and a personal brand

Yellow can be **bold** without the same story of passion that red often tells. It can feel **playful, unexpected or lightly provocative**. **Try** one yellow motif on a poster or a detail next to a photograph of your own work. It is meant to introduce you, not to out-shout you in colour.

Care, rest and sensitive topics

Here I would try gentler shades and a smaller amount. If women arrive tired, there is no need for compulsory sunshine to greet them at the door. Ask what the visitor should expect. **Playfulness and meeting**, or **quiet and relief**? Yellow can be part of both, but each time differently.

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Professions where it is a No

It does not suit **prestigious finance, law and luxury,** where yellow can feel loud and cheap (gold yes, yellow less so). Also **calm** and sleep (meditation, therapy) and everywhere you want to appear long-term and restrained. A richly yellow website with white text will unfortunately be unreadable.

This is not a ban on yellow for a whole field. What decides is how much of it you use, what shade it has and what a woman is meeting at your place right now. Here, though, I would be sparing with a large radiant area.

- **Funeral services, accompaniment in grief, crisis help**. A cheerful lemon across a whole website can feel as if there were no room for the other side's **pain**. A woman needs to feel she can come here even without a smile. I would choose a calmer base; a soft warm detail may stay if it belongs naturally in the whole.
- **Massage for deep rest, a meditation space, evening relaxation**. If you promise stillness, a large sharp yellow and black contrasts may visually tell more of bustle and activity. **Try** butter, sand or yellow only in a detail. The client came to put the day down, not to take on another shift in the sun.
- **Law, accounting, financial advice**. When a woman is dealing with obligations or a contract, she needs clarity and a sense of reliability. A playful yellow across a whole presentation can overshadow the seriousness of the service. As a detail next to a restrained base, though, it can pleasantly distinguish the brand. A yellow logo by itself does not lower trustworthiness; judge the whole impression.
- **A brand built on quiet elegance and privacy**. A garishly yellow packaging can drown out exactly the subtlety for which a woman chose you. A small yellow element or a more muted shade can give the product room and still keep its individuality.

The rule is simple. When you sell **joy**, an idea and catching attention, yellow will help you. When you sell **calm** and prestige, it will be too loud.

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Before you send it out into the world

Show the design to a woman who does not know your offer, and ask “What would you expect from such a place or service?” **Is the offer visible, or mainly the yellow?** Her answer may tell you more than the general rule that yellow means optimism.

A question for you

“What should your customer feel first when she looks at your website?”

Examples from the market

You know yellow from shops, adverts and the street. Here are a few examples that show what it can do.

- **McDonald's (fast food)**
  The first franchise restaurant with the double arches opened in May 1953 in Phoenix, Arizona. Two arches of yellow sheet metal with neon were already called golden at the design stage. Today's form of the arches logo dates from 1968. Yellow here is a trademark that you remember.

- **Post-it (office supplies)**
  The yellow paper of the notes was not a thought-out intention. According to the available sources it was scrap paper from a neighbouring laboratory. In 1977 the notes were test-sold as Press ’n Peel, in 1978 they got the name Post-it and in 1980 they came to market across the USA. Aha. A colour does not have to be planned to become a trademark.

- **DHL (courier services)**
  The company was founded in 1969 and the first logo had white letters on a red background. A yellow background with red lettering came with the takeover by Deutsche Post. According to the company yellow is linked with speed, which suits logistics.

- **Timberland (footwear)**
  The boot came out in 1973 and is still called the Yellow Boot. It is the brand's best-known model and the colour became a name.

What they have in common is that yellow carries a simple message. Watch out, visible, playful. And it is mostly not everywhere, only where it is meant to stand out.

Colours in business are not law. Studies are mixed and a lot depends on context, on customers and on how consistent the brand is. Take it as an idea to test, not as a rule. The brand examples are publicly known and the facts about them come from public sources.

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